

important early influence on Messiaen.



CONCERT OF BIRDS

Increasingly obsessed by ornithology, Messiaen used birdsong as a model for some of his music—these innovative works are some of the most challenging in the piano repertoire. This 17th-century painting of a concert of birds led by an owl choirmaster (center) is by Flemish painter Paul de Vos (c. 1591–1678).

Changing circumstances

Meanwhile, Messiaen's personal circumstances were changing dramatically. In 1927, his mother died. She had been suffering from depression for years, often locking herself away from the family. Shortly afterward, Messiaen met his future wife Claire Delbos, marrying her in 1932. She was a talented violinist and the pair performed a number of recitals together in the early 1930s.